



SEA SLUG STORIES

Thrilling Tales of U Boat Hunting, Told by an American Boy Who Served For Months With the British Patrol and Who Did the Thrilling and Perilous Work That Is Now Being Done by Hundreds of Other American Boys.

No. 2
Mine Sweeping With the M. L.'s
(Motor Launches)
By
A SEA SLUG,
British Service Name For Crews of Submarine Chasers.
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PROLOGUE.
The author of this series of four articles is a young American, who has spent most of his time since the war started with the British patrol fleet, taking an important part in helping to organize that branch of the service known as the Sea Slugs.

He has accumulated a remarkable collection of anecdotes incident to this exciting branch of the service, and many of these were personal adventures in which he took part and which make one of the stirring narratives to come out of the war. He recently returned to the United States to assist the American navy in organizing the same branch of the service and should be of great value because of his experience abroad. So far as known, he is the only American to serve with the British patrol prior to the advent of the United States destroyer flotilla in British waters. Of course some of his experiences, of military value to the enemy, cannot be related. At the request of the service publication of his name is withheld.

MAX HORTON, the man who torpedoed the German battle cruiser Moltke, was one of the most modest men I have ever met. I palled around for a couple of nights with Horton and another Sea Slug who had been only a short time out of the Hasda hospital, where he had recovered from wounds he received at Gallipoli. Horton, besides being the hero of the Moltke incident when in command of an E boat, had been the first man through the Dardanelles in his flimsy M. L., as the British call the submarine chasers, he being in that service before taking over a submarine.

M. L. stand for motor launch. The little craft are called a great many other things at times, both by the men in them when they don't run just right and by submarine commanders, German and British.

We were all at Portsmouth, which is one of the principal M. L. bases. Horton, his friend and myself had been

out on a duty tour and on the way back stopped at The Knut for a couple of drinks, then at Monk's for oysters and finally landed at Tot's for dinner, which is about the program followed by the Sea Slugs when they can get ashore.

"They had the M. L.'s sweeping mines down at Gallipoli," said Horton in a very matter of fact way. "Lots of people think all we Slugs have to do is to cruise around and keep from drowning, but I want to tell you that chasing submarines is the easiest and safest thing expected of us."

"Tugboats and trawlers and mine sweepers weren't much good in the Dardanelles, because they furnished too big a target. Besides, everything that could float was getting shot to pieces, and before they dared send our ships in it was absolutely necessary to sweep the mine fields."

"We used to look thousand foot cables between two M. L.'s and cruise down through the fields as fast as we could go. The cables were supposed to foul the mines, tip them over and explode them. They did it. Also the M. L.'s themselves tipped over several mines and exploded them, and after that there wasn't anything to look that end of the cable to."

Work Under Point Blank Fire.

"The Turkish batteries on the cliffs were so close that as we drove down through the mine fields we were at point blank range. The ammunition wasn't so very good, and it didn't always explode on contact, but if ever one of the heavy shells smashed through a chaser there wasn't much of anything left but the hole it made on the way through—like a doughnut after you eat it."

"Of course the Turk guns firing into the fields detonated a lot of their own mines, but that didn't do our comfort any, for many of them were right under some of the M. L.'s."

"One day we were sweeping in near shore. The sun was so hot that pitch seemed to sweat out and run down the decks. The glare off the water was almost blinding, and it really didn't seem as if it could be much better in the other place to which we might go if one of those shells hit us. The Turkish batteries were hammering away at us, but the terrific heat was so uncomfortable that nobody minded the shells much. All of a sudden something went by our stomach so close I thought it had cut me in two. Just beyond my boat a shell splashed into the water."

"One of the smaller projectiles had grazed and seared me. I caved in so that I couldn't walk straight or erect for several days—and that is literally true. My stomach felt all the time as if some one was drawing a red hot knife across it."

"I got it worse than that," said the other chap, who had been in the hos-

pital, abruptly. "My boat bumped a mine. I don't know how it is to get shot, but when that thing blew up right alongside of us it felt to me as though it was my own body exploding. It seemed like a sudden and terrible pressure from the inside of me that was going to burst me like a toy balloon."

"We finally got back to the tender under our own power. We had to shore up the bows a little, but we managed to make it. Mines do freakish things, and I don't believe there is a man living who can give any logical reason why we weren't blown into atoms."

"Plain luck, I guess," observed Horton placidly. "It's funny that a mine powerful enough to sink an ocean liner or a battleship will sometimes explode and fail to destroy a motor launch or a submarine that is almost alongside it. A lot of people think submarines are very easily put out of business. We Sea Slugs know it's different, especially the U boats. I saw one of our own down at Gallipoli which had hit a mine and came in with her bow patched up under her own power, just as you did in your chaser."

Sixteen Dead In Launch.

"I never had the bad luck to bump a mine myself, but I've had my share of being shot up. I had one end of a cable in a mine sweeping stunt at the Dardanelles one night when the Turkish batteries got the range. The fire they poured into us is almost unbelievable. I don't see how a stick lived through it. We were practically under water all the time, the shells were falling so close and spraying us so steadily."

"Every once in a while one came on board, but they were not exploding right—that is, not right from the Turkish point of view. We were perfectly satisfied to have them fall to go off."

"The other chap, though, the fellow who had the far end of my cable, was getting it pretty badly. He was in terrible shape, and after a particularly vicious burst of fire his engines stopped and he began to drift. I ran over to him. We couldn't sweep with only one end of the cable in motion."

"Of the eighteen men in the other M. L. I found two alive. They weren't conscious, but they were still alive. The sixteen others were dead. We took these two aboard our launch and got back to the base. That night was hell."

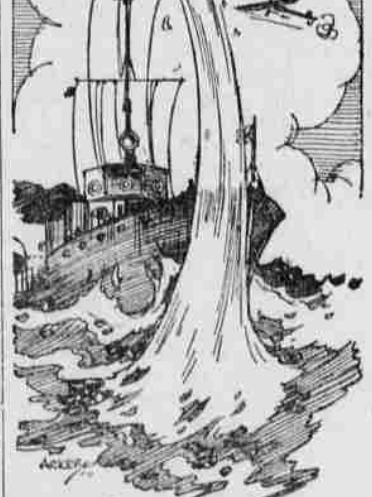
I have quoted the stories told me by these two men as nearly in their words as I can remember them to show a phase of the submarine chasers' work which is seldom thought of. As Horton said, most people think the M. L.'s do nothing but cruise around in comparative safety looking for submarines. This is only one of their duties."

Most of the Sea Slugs have been taught to operate machine guns, and as a result they were frequently used for landing parties at Gallipoli, running in under the Turkish guns and trying to hang on, by their finger nails almost, to the cliffs. Some of the Sea Slugs were on shore for a long time and served in the trenches. One of them told me a bad feature of the fighting there was trying to keep clean. There wasn't water enough to drink, to say nothing about washing, and the only way they could clean their shirts was to lay them on the ant hills. Even at that if they left them there too long the shirts themselves would disappear."

Another job the M. L.'s had down there was boarding all the fishing smacks and other apparently non-combatant vessels and searching them for ammunition and mines. I talked to one man named D., a brother of the officer I told about in my first article who rammed one of his own submarines, mistaking her for a German, who had a fight with two Turk aeroplanes while he was visiting a number of such vessels.

Fought Planes With Rifles.

"We are just running over to a fishing smack to search her," said D., "when I hear the throbbing of an aero-



Bang! Goes One Not Thirty Feet Off My Starboard Bow.

plane engine. A few seconds later the roar of another engine cuts in, and presently I locate them with my glasses. It never occurs to me that they are after such small fry as my little M. L.

"Round and round they circle just over our heads, getting lower and lower all the time, until at last they start dropping bombs."

"Bang! Goes one not thirty feet off my starboard bow, and we are sprayed with the foam she throws up. But the target is too small, and the planes are traveling so fast they can't get us with bombs, so they veer off and come

skimming back very low in a straight line dead for us. They are so close to our heads that I feel like ducking, just as one does going under a doorway that is actually high enough to walk through upright, but which looks too low."

"Suddenly they begin to spray us with machine gun fire. Two of my men are hit, and the decks are flying into splinters. All I have on board is a couple of 30-30 rifles, and I begin firing with one, while my first officer uses the other. The three pounder can't be elevated enough to use it as an air gun."

"We can shoot rapidly, but nothing like the fire of that cursed spew of lead spraying from those machine guns."

"Once they drive straight over us, and now they are coming back. If we don't stop them this time we are gone. I squint along the sights of my rifle. I take a deep breath. I let part of it out and hold the rest, so that my shoulder will not be moving as I squeeze the trigger."

"I am sighting right for the pilot's chest. I fire. He veers off like a wounded bird. His plane wobbles. It looks as if it was going to fall, but he gets it straightened out and flies away. Both of us begin to fire at the other machine. It rises. The pilot does not dare to fly straight into the rifle fire. From aloft he contents himself with dropping more bombs, but he must be within range of our rifles, for presently he flies away and does not bother us any more."

"If he had been a German air man the end of the story might have been different."

Sea Slugs Are Fighters.

The crews which officer and man the submarine chasers are not trained navy men. They don't know overmuch of the king's regulations, and the discipline they maintain is most certainly not that to which one is accustomed on board ship."

But—and I want to emphasize this strongly—they are scrappers. They fight in their own way. They may not know how to do it according to the book, but they are among the gamest men afloat. Many of them are wealthy and formerly owned and operated their own boats. They are a hard fighting, hard riding crew, and the devil himself can't scare them."

Before they are assigned to boats the men are given about a ten day course in navigation, for they must sometimes cruise out of sight of land and at night. Many amusing and sometimes almost tragic incidents arise from their inexperience."

I was out once in an M. L. commanded by a subaltern named C. All he knew about navigation had been taught him in ten days. He got lost, was ashamed to say so and admit that he didn't know how to get his location. He figured for two days trying to find out where he was. He'd get his sun observations, and by the time he had the readings calculated he'd be so far away that he had to do it all over again."

He figured for two days, and all the time he was getting shorter in provisions and fuel. By the first half day he followed a destroyer, thinking she was running into port. He wouldn't signal her and ask for instructions or for his location, so he just trailed along after her as though he knew where he was going. He was too proud to ask the road home."

The sun was under clouds, but it came out just before sunset, and he discovered that he had been running right away from England. We got back off Portsmouth at night. But our signal box had been lost overseas, and we couldn't reply to the signal at the entrance to the harbor, which came within inches of costing us our lives, as our own batteries fired a couple of 4.7's at us, and we had to run out and cruise around the rest of the night to save our skins. However, we hung in sight of the harbor so as not to get lost again."

This same chap, though he was short on the science of navigation, was long on fight. When cruising at night the M. L.'s, of course, show no lights, and it is very hard to maintain an absolutely even speed and keep just the proper distance from the other craft."

Steam engines can be controlled right down to the inch, but the gas engines which drive the M. L.'s are not so readily regulated. A single notch increase or decrease on the throttle may make a difference of a whole knot in speed."

Well, C. lost track of the other chasers in his squadron one night, and he didn't dare signal to them. They were out searching for submarines, and to show lights would only give the whole thing away. He couldn't take a chance on sending up a rocket or tooting his whistle, for secrecy is everything. So he just hid a course the way he thought he ought to steer and kept it up hell bent all night."

Just after daylight he discovered that he was off the Belgian coast, having crossed the channel. As the early morning mist lifted he sighted a big vessel astern flying the German flag. She didn't look like a regular warship—more like a converted yacht—but she mounted one gun forward, and C. could see others aft."

He had a regulation three inch piece himself."

"Well, boys," he said to his crew, "we may be rotten navigators, but we don't need to know navigation to give that tub a fight. What do you say?"

There was only about one chance in a hundred that any of them would come out of the scrap alive, and C. didn't like to order his men into it. The M. L. was so fast she could have run, but the crew was game, so C. put about and began to loop around in order to cross her bows, thinking to cut loose a few raking shots into the craft."

The gun was loaded and ready to

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Fine Fleece-Ribbed Cotton Vests and Pants. Shown in white and gray. Priced, according to size, at 40c to 50c a Garment.

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HOMES ARE MUCH IN DEMAND; RENTS HIGH

Business men fear that some civic or commercial agency will have to take steps in Oregon City to relieve the house famine that is keeping many families out of Oregon City at the present time, according to talk on the streets. Houses suitable for habitation are not to be had in the city at any price and as soon as a desirable location is vacated it is taken by some one of half a dozen families on the waiting list.

"What the city most needs," says A. C. Howland, who through his connection with the realty business understands the situation, "is scores of small dwellings to accommodate medium sized families. If capital would invest in a group of bungalows the profit would warrant the investment more than at any other time in recent years, for rents are better and occupation of the premises assured. A suitable apartment house is also one of the great needs of the city."

When the question of building a group of dwellings was put up to one of the most prosperous men in the city some time ago by a group of interested business men, he made light of the suggestion by saying:

"Invested in houses my money can only make 5 per cent and I can't

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Will Be Repaid For Their Work

Women everywhere suffer from kidney trouble—backache, rheumatic pains, swollen and tender muscles, stiff joints—and it is to help those who suffer as she did that Mrs. C. J. Ellis, 508 Av., Sioux Falls, S. D., writes: "I feel sure if any one bothered as I was will give Foley Kidney Pills a fair trial they will be repaid for their work. It seems foolish to neglect an ailment when there is such a remedy to be had." They correct bladder disturbances, too.—Jones Drug Co.

Will Appeal to President

What appears to be the first serious contest of the ruling of the local and district draft boards by a Clackamas county conscript is threatened by E. J. Baurer, whose claim for exemption has been denied by both boards. Because his affidavits were said to be fraudulent, the district board refused to recognize the appeal for exemption made by Baurer, and on Saturday he served notice on the local board that he would appeal from the ruling direct to the president.

Soldier Married

Theresa Lehman and Harland Watson were married at the office of Deputy District Attorney Thomas A. Burke Tuesday by Major Gilbert, chaplain of the 3rd Oregon infantry, of which the groom is a member. Both are residents of Clackamas, Mr. Watson being there temporarily with the troops.

A marriage license was issued Tuesday to Armetta Addington and Victor C. Jubb of Oregon City, route 6.

The Courier and the Daily Journal \$4.75.

DIDN'T LIKE WATCH

Morris Goldman Held Up in Portland Business District

Two holdup men robbed Morris Goldman, 419 Main street, Oregon City, of \$2.50 at Third and Market streets Portland, Sunday night, but refused to take his watch because it was not expensive enough, according to Mr. Goldman's report to the Portland police.

Mr. Goldman said one of the men pointed a revolver at him, while the

other rifled his pockets. After looking at the watch, Mr. Goldman said, the searcher handed it back to the owner with the remark that it was not worth taking.

J. W. Hassing, a Portland wife murderer, who escaped last week from the penitentiary, where he was serving a life term, has been located in the mountains 18 miles south of Salem. A posse has gone in pursuit. Hassing called at several ranch houses for food within the last few days and was recognized.

fore, and C. was only waiting for what he thought was the best position before giving the order to shoot.

"We ought to fly our flag if we're going into battle," suggested some one in the crew.

"By Jove, you're right," C. agreed, and in a jiffy the British ensign was run up at the M. L.'s stern.

Like a shot the German flag at the stern of the war vessel came down, and the Union Jack took its place. Simultaneously from the masthead the stranger broke out a private British navy signal, and C. replied.

He had come within an ace of firing into one of his own vessels which had been flying the German flag in order to decoy any German craft that might



He Sighted a Big Vessel Astern Flying the German Flag.

sight her. It shows, though, that the Sea Slugs are ready to go into action any time and that they don't have to have the odds in their favor either."

(Continued next week)

TAKE IT IN TIME

Just as Scores of Oregon City People Have

Waiting doesn't pay. If you neglect kidney backache, Bladder troubles often follow. Doan's Kidney Pills are for kidney backache, and for other kidney ills.

Oregon City citizens endorse them. Mrs. W. H. Dempster, 216 Fourteenth St., Oregon City, says: "I used to have weak kidneys and they acted too freely. After I had taken Doan's Kidney Pills a few weeks I got rid of the trouble. It is only once in a great while now that I notice symptoms of the former complaint but a few doses of Doan's Kidney Pills soon put my kidneys in good working order."

Price 60c at all dealers. Don't simply ask for a kidney remedy—get Doan's Kidney Pills—the same that Mrs. Dempster uses. Foster-Milburn Co., Mfgs., Buffalo, N. Y.

Hardware Firm Gets Judgment

Judgment in the sum of \$181.37 was given the Peters Hardware company Saturday in its suit against Adolph Koellmeier. Certain of defendant's property in section 8, town-

ship 3 south, range 1 east, was ordered sold to satisfy the judgment.

Says Husband Is Contemptuous
Eliza M. Gleason, married to R. M. Gleason at Cottage Grove on August 3, 1910, wants to divorce her husband

because of his contemptuous and neglectful treatment. She would have her maiden name, Eliza Mager, restored to her. Mrs. Gleason says she was forced to leave her husband in April of this year.

ECONOMY

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